CARGO HANDLING

Antwerp Container port trade

Text One – Container trade

This year the volume of containerised goods came to 74.6 million tonnes, or 6.5 million TEU. Over the last 10 years container tonnage has risen by 42.5 million tonnes or 164.7%.At present, 78% of all general cargo is containerised. Last year the nine principal ports of the Le Havre-Hamburg range jointly handled 28.4 million TEU, or a total tonnage of 298 million tonnes. In terms of tonnage as well as of TEU Antwerp is the third largest container port in the range, after Rotterdam and Hamburg, and has a market share of 21.3%.

Text Two – Container trade by geographical region in 2005 Text based on table © Antwerp Port Authority

Container trade with Europe was 19.7% of the total of 74.6 million tonnes. The Near East was slightly more, 20.3%. Trade with the Mid and Far East was slightly less than that with Europe, 19.2%. Trade with North and Central America was 0.8% under 25% at 24.2%. Trade with South America and Africa lagged behind at 5.7% and 9.2% respectively.Other regions made up the remaining 1.7% trade.

Text Three - Port of Antwerp – Container traffic in 2005 (in tonnes) – Full containers

The number of full containers unloaded from Europe was 5,210,121.
The number of full containers loaded for Europe was 9,545,549.
giving a total of 14,755,670.
The number of full containers unloaded from the Near East was 5,451,874.
The number of full containers loaded for the Near East was 9,431,519
giving a total of 14,883,393
The number of full containers unloaded from the Middle & Far East was 5,147,976.
The number of full containers loaded for the Middle & Far East was 9,075,391
giving a total of 14,223,367
The number of full containers unloaded from North & Central America was 8,010,124
The number of full containers loaded for North & Central America was 8,250,502
giving a total of 16,260,626
The number of full containers unloaded from South America was 2,184,113

The number of full containers loaded for South America was 2,384,074

giving a total of 4,568,187

The number of full containers unloaded from Africa was 2,833,753

The number of full containers loaded for Africa was 3,869,554

giving a total of 6,703,307

The number of full containers unloaded from other destinations was 153,634

The number of full containers loaded for other destinations was 557,419

giving a total of 711,053

Introduction to cargo care

A successful containerised cargo shipment depends on four basic fundamentals.

1. Matching the cargo to the correct type of container that is best suited for the forthcoming voyage.
2. Ensuring that the container is in good condition prior to loading the cargo and that it is carried and handled correctly throughout the voyage.
3. Ensuring that the cargo is loaded correctly into the container and is properly secured against movement during the voyage.
4. Ensuring that all the relevant cargo information is communicated to all appropriate parties to ensure that the container and its contents will arrive at the consignee in the expected condition.

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Cargo Handling – Bill of Lading definitions

In order to understand a Bill of Lading, it is important to be familiar with certain definitions.

'Carrier' Means the party named in the Signature Box on the face of this document.

'Merchant' Includes any Person who at any time has been or becomes the Shipper, Holder, Consignee, Receiver of the Goods, any Person who owns or is entitled to the possession of the Goods or of this Bill of Lading and any Person acting on behalf of any such Person.

'Holder' Means any Person for the time being in possession of (or entitled to the possession of) this Bill of Lading.

'Person' Includes an individual, group, company or other entity.

'Sub-Contractor' Includes (but is not limited to) owners and operators of any vessels (other than the Carrier), stevedores, terminal and groupage operators, road, rail and air transport operators and any independent contractor employed by the Carrier in performance of the Carriage and any sub-sub-contractors thereof.

'Indemnify' Includes defend, indemnify and hold harmless whether or not the obligation to indemnify arises out of negligent or non-negligent acts or omissions of the Carrier, his servants, agents or Sub-Contractors.

'Goods' Means the whole or any part of the cargo received from the Shipper and includes the packing and any equipment or Container not supplied by or on behalf of the Carrier.

'Container' Includes any container, trailer, transportable tank, flat or pallet, or any similar article used to consolidate goods and any ancillary equipment.

'Carriage' Means the whole or any part of the operations and services undertaken by the Carrier in respect of the Goods covered by this Bill of Lading.

'Port of Loading' Means any port at which the Goods are loaded on board any Vessel (which may not necessarily be the Vessel named elsewhere in this document) for Carriage under this Bill of Lading

'Port of Discharge' Means any port at which the Goods are discharged from any Vessel (which may not necessarily be the Vessel named elsewhere in this document) after Carriage under this Bill of Lading.

'Vessel' Means any waterborne craft used in the Carriage under this Bill of Lading which may be a feeder vessel or an ocean vessel.

'Combined Transport' Arises if the Place of Receipt and/or the Place of Delivery are indicated on the face of this document in the relevant spaces.

'Port to Port' Arises if the Carriage is not Combined Transport.

'Shipped on Board' Relates only to the Container into which the Goods are manifested.

'Freight' Includes all charges payable to the Carrier in accordance with the applicable Tariff and this Bill of Lading.

'Hague Rules' Means the provisions of the International Convention for the Unification of Certain Rules relating to Bills of Lading signed at Brussels on 25th August, 1924 and includes the amendments by the Protocol signed at Brussels on 23rd February, 1968, but only if such amendments are compulsorily applicable to this Bill of Lading. (It is expressly provided that nothing in this Bill of Lading shall be construed as contractually applying said Rules as amended by said Protocol).

Refrigerated cargo

Most vessels are nowadays involved in the carriage of refrigerated cargoes all over the world, travelling through climates as hot as the torrid summers of the Persian Gulf and as cold as the frigid winters of the Antarctic Ocean. The combination of the cargo temperature requirements and the climatic variations means correct temperature control of the refrigeration unit is essential, ensuring the cargo reaches its final destination in the desired condition. Shippers have developed extensive knowledge and expertise in the carriage of world-wide temperature controlled cargoes. They transport their customer's cargoes efficiently and effectively from the point of loading all the way through to the final destination, ensuring the cargo arrives in pristine condition for the final customer.

Engine problems aboard a container ship

Report from Arnie Spencer, Captain of a container ship which trades from the Far East to the west coast of the USA

"Hi, I'm Arnie Spencer. Since my last dispatch, we have been to the port of Long Beach for our full discharge and load. Whilst in the harbour, we performed our regular three-monthly test of the lifeboat, lowering it into the water and taking it for a spin around the harbour, which was most enjoyable. The engineering department took the opportunity of our time in harbour to open up an engine cylinder and check the piston rings. If there is any wear, the piston rings are changed and the piston crown is cleaned up and replaced. This means that on departure the new pistons must be run in, meaning that we have to very gradually increase our speed over a 12-hour period in order not to cause any damage to the new pistons.

On our way across the Pacific, we encountered an engine problem, which meant that all engineers had to take turns on sea watch, much to their annoyance. On today's modern vessels, the engine room is unmanned at night with one engineer covering alarms over each 24-hour period. Therefore, taking part in watches throughout the night is a shock to the system compared to the usual 8-5 daytime shift. Hopefully, the problem will be fixed shortly and we will be back to normal after our second call to Singapore".